

Case Study 1: Ethics & Your Career

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WHAT'S COVERED

In this case study, you will consider a series of decisions to make as you navigate through trying to find a job and acclimate to a new job setting. In particular, you will make decisions about:

1. The Resume

You've recently graduated with your bachelor's degree in business with an emphasis in project management. Your goal is to be a project manager eventually, but you know you may have to work your way up to that position. So, you've been looking for assistant project manager positions.

You feel your resume is solid. Currently, although you haven't really managed a large project for a company before, you have coordinated fundraising events for the animal rescue you volunteer for. You coordinated an event called "Santa and Hounds," where people could have their animal's picture taken with Santa. The event was a success and ended up raising over \$5,000 for the charity. You've also done other projects, such as managing a full kitchen and bathroom remodel in your home. You know you'll make a great project manager due to your organizational skills.

Despite the fact your degree is in project management, you are not getting any requests for interviews, which is really disappointing. So, you decide to have a few friends review your resume and give feedback. One of your friends, Kenzie, asks about your project management experience, and you tell her about the fundraising and other home projects. She thinks you haven't gotten any interviews for project management because your resume doesn't have any previous job titles of assistant project manager or similar.

She says, "Why don't you just state that for the animal rescue, you are their project manager for all events? If you tell them you are going to do that, I'm sure they'd vouch for you if any company calls for a reference." You get a bit of a pit in your stomach because you know she is probably right. If you put that on your resume, the director would vouch for you, and you'd have a better chance of at least getting an interview where you can shine.



TRY IT

What should you do in this situation?

[Look for a different type of position.](#)



Although this could be a valid choice, the assumption is that you have your heart set on project management. Assuming this is the case, looking for a different type of position would be

disappointing. But perhaps you could look at companies hiring for a different type of position, say, as an administrative assistant, with the hope you could be promoted to assistant project manager once you've proven yourself. If so, be sure to ask in any interviews if the job includes mentorship and professional development.

Go back to school and earn a master's degree in project management.

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Certainly, more education doesn't hurt! However, this choice could be costly and still doesn't really solve your problem about lack of experience. Instead, you could consider looking for an internship or asking the animal rescue if you could volunteer as their project manager to gain experience for the type of position you want.

Keep your resume as is but try to find other ways to highlight your project management skills.

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This is the best choice. Lying on a resume has many ramifications, and if you asked the director of the rescue to lie for you, they may question your values and change their opinion about you. One thing you could do, as opposed to lying, is have a professional resume writer review your resume and help you highlight your skills.

Talk to the animal rescue director prior to making a decision.

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The challenge in even talking with the animal rescue director about possibly lying for you is that they may view you differently after asking them to be unethical themselves. If you decided to lie on your resume about your role in "Santa and Hounds," you'd definitely want to talk with the director first to ensure they'll vouch for you, but there are risks, such as what if an employer finds out you exaggerated your experience? Some jobs will terminate you if they discover you misrepresented yourself. One thing you could do is find a way to highlight your project management skills by revising your resume but not lying about your experience.

2. The Interview

You decided to be honest on your resume, and finally, after revising it to highlight your legitimate skills and experience, companies reach out and ask to schedule interviews! You are excited because you were honest in your resume, and now you have a chance in the interview to really shine and show off your skills.

You spend several hours preparing for the three interviews you have in the coming week. You feel ready for the interviews and are excited. On the morning of your first interview, you dress carefully and arrive early. The office looks exciting to work in, as there are no cubicles, but a big open space with games and music. You already know you want to work here.

As you wait nervously in the reception area, the person interviewing you calls you and introduces himself. "They seem friendly enough," you think to yourself. You follow him back to a meeting room. As you walk past, people smile encouragingly, which helps ease your nerves.

They ask you a variety of questions, but then something odd happens. One person asks you if you’ve “always been this attractive,” and makes a comment about needing more attractive people in this office. You know it’s illegal to ask questions about age or marital status but aren’t sure what the law says about a question like this one, even if it is supposed to be a compliment. You’re taken aback and don’t quite know how to respond, especially given that you think you’d really like to work there.



What is the best way to respond to this inappropriate question?

Ask them how your looks are relevant to the position.

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This is the best choice. It brings the conversation back to the job and takes the focus off physical appearance. While this may be hard to do during an interview, especially given it is a job you really want, this sets your boundaries and allows you to really understand what type of person you’d be working with.

Tell them you aren’t interested in the job anymore.

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This choice might be a bit extreme. One comment doesn’t necessarily mean it is a bad place to work. It means that this person has an issue. Perhaps it would be good to understand in what capacity you would be working with this person. Would you have to work with them day to day? Or only once in a while? If these comments continued, would you be comfortable with that? Do you get a sense as to whether these types of comments are acceptable in the company culture? Answers to these questions might determine if you’d even want the job.

Send an email to human resources once you’re home.

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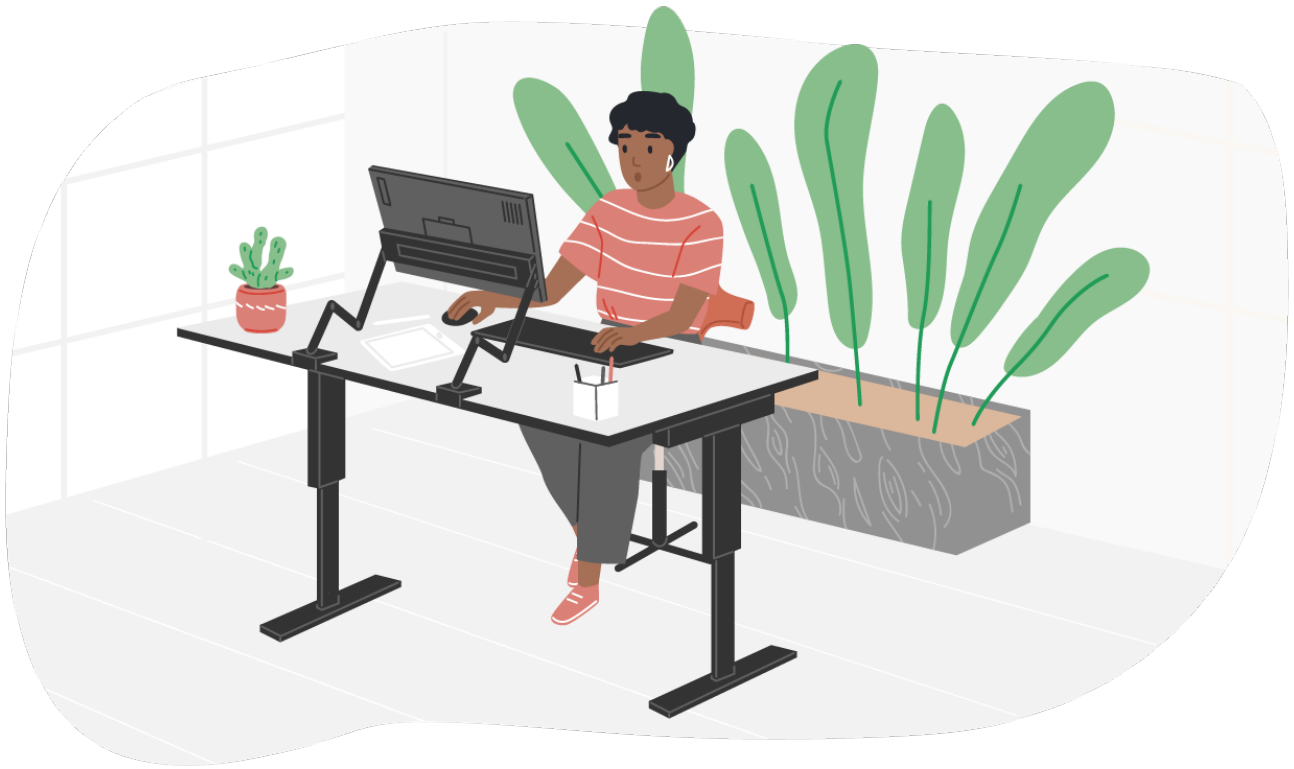
Since you do not work for the organization yet, this is probably not the best choice. In this type of situation, it is usually best to set your boundaries and ask how your looks are relevant to the position. This can be said in a kind way, and if you do not get the job because you stick up for yourself, then perhaps it isn’t the right fit anyway.

Say nothing. You really want this position and don’t want to upset them.

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While this might be a really tempting choice, it is not setting your boundaries from the very beginning of your working relationship. The best thing to do is to deflect the question while also signaling that you don’t consider it appropriate. For example, you could say, “I’m not sure what my looks have to do with my project management skills. Speaking of that, I’d like to tell you about a fundraiser I did for an animal rescue where I coordinated the entire event.” While it might be hard to stand up for yourself, you probably don’t want to work in a place where these kinds of comments are commonplace.

3. Admitting Mistakes



You've landed the project management assistant job! You are happy with your choice, as you believe your team to be strong and you are learning a lot from the project manager you work for.

Currently, you are working on a large-scale information technology project which requires computer upgrades, including software on over 100 computers in the office. You've built trust with your supervisor, and they have let you take the lead on this project, with them as your mentor.

A few weeks into the project, the IT team is loading software into the computer, and you note that you never put software in the project management budget. You feel embarrassed, as this is one of the most important pieces, and the senior project manager didn't notice it either.

When you go to check your project budget, you see that over \$10,000 was spent on software that wasn't in the original budget. You are so upset over this, as you hate to have made such a big mistake when you've been trusted to handle the project.

After a lot of thinking, you decide you will just talk with your supervisor about it. When you go to their office, you close the door and tell them what happened. They tell you, "Oh, don't worry about it, it's not a big deal. Just go back to the original project plan the Chief Financial Officer (CFO) signed off on and add in the line item. They'll never notice; it's such a small expense compared to all of the other IT expenses. I've had to do that before." To you, this feels like falsifying a document.

You consider your options and how the ethical decision you make could impact your career as a project manager.



What should you do in this situation?

Do as the project manager says and add in the \$10,000.

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While this is tempting to do because then you don't have to admit your mistake, it is not the most

ethical thing to do. To do this would be dishonest, and possibly compromise your future career. Instead, you should own up to your mistake and try to fix it as best as you can, for example, by saving money in the budget elsewhere or seeing if there is an official process to modify the budget.

Talk to the CFO directly and ask them if you can add the funds to the account.

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This is the best choice. Admitting to a mistake is hard to do, but important, and it shows someone with high values and ethics. By owning up to your mistake, you are showing that you are a trustworthy employee. Of course, the downside is that you could threaten your job, or not be trusted for some time with projects, but at least you'll be able to sleep at night knowing you were honest.

Ask your supervisor to make the change on the document.

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It is worrisome that your supervisor states they've done this before, suggesting a less-than-ethical attitude. Even so, by asking them to do it, you are equally as unethical as they are, so this is not a good choice. You can simply explain to them you're not comfortable doing that, and that you'll talk with the CFO prior to making the addition.

Quit the position, as it is too embarrassing to stay there.

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This is a bit extreme. While it probably is embarrassing, it is the job you've been wanting, so it is best to stick with it! Admitting your mistake to the CFO is the best choice, because it shows your good character!



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you considered the ethical dilemmas when you apply for jobs and adjust to new jobs. While you may be tempted to lie on **your resume** or ignore inappropriate comments during **an interview**, it is important to maintain high ethical expectations of yourself and of your coworkers to be successful and happy in the long term. Perhaps the most difficult challenge is **admitting mistakes** at a new job, but a good employer will appreciate your honesty and transparency, and see this as an opportunity to help you learn the position.

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